



BIOGRAPHY

PARYSATIS

Born around 436 BCE, Queen Parysatis was the formidable wife and half-sister of King Darius II. She held sway over the Persian court during the reign of her husband and into that of her son, Artaxerxes II. Parysatis was very wealthy, with estates in Iran, Syria, and Mesopotamia. She was also ruthless: she ordered her opponents to be crucified, flayed, and hung. Parysatis championed her son Cyrus the Younger to become king in place of his elder brother. When Cyrus's plot to take the throne failed, Parysatis was exiled in Babylon, but later returned to court, where she poisoned Artaxerxes' main wife to secure her own power.

360
Greek
concubines
were at court
at one time

◀ **Queen of Persia**

The story of Esther—a Jewish wife of Persian King Xerxes I who saved her people from getting massacred—is an ancient tale mentioned in several religious texts, including the Hebrew Bible.